

Bilaga 1: CoARA Action plan 2025–2027

Preamble

Linköping university (LiU), one of the largest and broadest public university in Sweden, signed the CoARA agreement in October 2022. Since signing the agreement, the university has intensified the work to strive for an open, transparent and fair reform of its merit systems of achievements and competences of academic personnel to meet future needs. To succeed with an efficient implementation of the principles of CoARA, the whole university need to be involved. Every entity's responsibility needs to be clear.

Governance and organisation

The university board is the highest decision-making body and is accountable to the government, ensuring the university meets its objectives. The University management consists of the vice-chancellor, appointed by the government; the deputy vice-chancellor appointed by the university board who is replacing the vice-chancellor when necessary; currently two vice-rectors appointed by the vice-chancellor; and the university director liable for university services and administrative operations.

LiU has four faculties: Arts and Sciences, Medicine and Health Sciences, Science and Engineering, and Educational Sciences. The faculties are responsible for education and research within their area, and commission services from the departments. Each faculty is run by a faculty board headed by a dean. Deans are elected by faculty on three-year terms. The faculties are responsible for ensuring that employment matters and promotions follow the university's principles and criteria for assessing merits and competences, which are indicated in the employment regulations decided by the University board.

Education and research are conducted by staff organized in different academic divisions at 12 multidisciplinary departments, led by the head of department who is reporting directly to the vice-chancellor.

Quality assurance processes of research

Ensuring high quality of the research conducted at LiU is multifaceted. First, assessing research contributions and overall academic achievements and merits needs support from units within the university services. Second, it is important to ensure regular evaluation processes and to follow-up of challenges identified. In 2025, LiU conducted the university's first ever comprehensive evaluation of the research performed within academic units at the twelve departments (LiRE25). The results and experiences from LiRE25 are important complements for ensuring the quality of research, the formation and performance of research units and doctoral programs, and the ability to offer attractive, equal and diverse career paths.

The Swedish Higher Education Authority (UKÄ), a governmental agency responsible for official statistics and monitoring the performance of higher education institutions (HEI) in Sweden, is currently evaluating the quality assurance processes for research. LiU is currently preparing for the process and organization for this up-coming external evaluation.

LiU obtained the HR Excellence in Research Award (H4S4R) from the European Commission in April 2025. In addition, the University board approved an Open science policy for the university in May 2025. Together with the LiU vision and strategic plan for 2022-2030 (dnr LiU-2022-00428), these lay the foundation for the continuing work and are important parts to reform research assessment at different levels at LiU and included in the LiU CoARA action plan for the coming three years (2025-2027). The action plan is organized in six focus areas with associated action points (AP). The APs are numbered in relation to the CoARA commitments (Table 1).

Specific focus areas

1. Recognition of diverse contributions to research when evaluating academic personnel at the individual level

This focus area involves evaluating individuals applying for an academic position or when staff members are applying for promotion to the next level of academic appointment and criteria used in the annual salary revision process.

Revise the LiU employment rules, processes and associated documents (AP 1.1)

The rules of employment cover criteria when hiring new personnel and for qualification for a higher position. Changes in rules are decided by the University board. The responsibility for securing a regular process of reviewing the rules of employment lies with the deans for the faculties, forming a working group together with two HR officers. An initial mapping of the CoARA commitments to the existing

employment rules has been performed. From January 2025, the CoARA coordinator is actively participating in the working group with the aim to raise CoARA perspectives in the documents as well as the processes and support the revision of the documents. LiUs recently approved its Open science policy which will be the basis for implementing contributions to open science in the evaluation of individuals. The work also includes revising instructions for reviewers, and training of academic appointment board members in employment matters.

Review and develop the LiU salary revision criteria (AP 1.4)

The annual salary revision at LiU is individual based on achievements in areas common to all employees and in specific research areas for researchers. The revision is performed as an individual dialogue between the employer and the immediate manager. Achievements are self-documented according to a template. This template includes all researchers at LiU. Hence, it needs to be conformed to CoARA principles and could lead to an important cultural change when assessing research achievements and contributions.

The salary revision template will benefit from a guideline with recommendations on best practice regarding how to report achievements and contributions, for instance to open science and how to report publications. The guidelines should discourage inappropriately reporting journal impact factors and suggest better metrics such as journal percentiles in their research field. The guidelines should also cover other publication channels such as books and reports. Furthermore, it should give advice on how to document academic citizenship and societal contributions and be applicable to researchers with shared positions between academia and society outside academia.

2. Reviewing and developing criteria for the evaluation of research performing units

Research units at LiU are primarily divisions and units at the 12 departments. This is how researchers at all levels are organized at LiU. Other research units are thematic studies units, institutes, centra, profile areas, areas of strength and strategic areas, and infrastructure units.

Advance the process of external peer review of research (AP 2.2)

LiU has during 2025 conducted the university's first ever comprehensive evaluation of the research conducted within all academic units at the 12 departments (LiRE25). The evaluation consists of data on research performance, a self-evaluation report from each unit, and external peer review-committee work. Based on the results and experiences of LiRE25, the university will at all levels monitor quality action plans for research as well as develop regular quality assurance processes based on external peer review, reforming the format to allow for diversity and the development of the use of peer review.

Identify the most important research output of LiU divisions (AP 1.2)

The LiRE25 result will be used to characterize each of LiUs almost 100 divisions in terms of their most important research output regarding diverse contributions such as: publications, publication channels, scientific communication, grants, granting agencies, collaboration with society, valorisation etc. The self-report document for the external reviewers and the reviewers report will be used to document the research output. The documentation is important when refining the department dialogue (AP 2.1) and for external communication.

Review the criteria for research assessment applied to LiU divisions (AP 6.1)

The LiRE25 result and the identification of the diverse research output by each of LiU divisions (AP 1.2), will be input to a review of research assessment strategies and criteria that are relevant for meeting the diversity in LiUs research. The strategies and criteria cover both external (AP 2.2) and internal research evaluations in the quality assessment plan for research.

Refine the department dialogues (AP 2.1).

At LiU, annual dialogues are performed between LiU management and the departments, and between the faculties and the departments. These dialogues are performed as face-to-face meetings with standardized questions and relevant metrics on performance such as publications, economic indicators, and recruitments and staffing. The dialogues are important arenas for evaluating the performance of the department and for knowledge exchange between different organizational levels. The dialogues can be further improved by identifying each divisions most important research output (AP 1.2), by a further developed responsible use of bibliometrics (AP 3.1), and by reviewing the criteria for research assessment when applied to LiU divisions (AP 6.1).

3. Responsible use of bibliometrics

Review and develop responsible use of bibliometrics at LiU (AP 3.1).

Within LiU, bibliometrics is used in the annual department dialogues between the management and the departments, and between the faculties and the departments (AP 2.1). Bibliometrics is also used at some faculties for distributing resources to research.

The goal is to propose measures better agreeing to responsible research assessment. This work will be developed in synergy with the working group “Responsible bibliometrics” within the CoARA National chapter in Sweden.

Faculty or department specific webinars on research dissemination and responsible bibliometrics (AP 7.3).

There is a diverse research dissemination in different research fields concerning journal publications, publications in books, reports and conferences. Webinars on research dissemination must be tailored to this diversity. Bibliometrics will continue to be important in research evaluation. Seminars on strategic publication and bibliometrics must cover responsible bibliometrics and the ongoing reform of bibliometrics. Staff from the University library will have an important role in these seminars together with local researchers.

4. Promote Open science (AP 1.3)

LiU has recently taken a decision on an open science policy. The policy will cover resources for advising researchers regarding publications channels, which data that can from legal and ethical points be shared, data repositories and how to handle meta data. Further actions involve including open science contributions in the employment rules, processes such as instructions to reviewers and documents such as CV templates (AP 1.1). Furthermore, open science contributions as an example of research achievement will be considered in the document used in the annual salary revision (AP 1.4).

5. Allocate resources to CoARA activities (AP 5.1)

The vice-chancellor of Linköping University is the chair of the CoARA national chapter of Sweden and the chair of a national commission to work with reforming the merit assessment systems at HEI in Sweden.

The CoARA coordinator is appointed by the vice-chancellor with dedicated resources. One staff member at the central administration, one contact person for open science at the university library, and several staff at the HR department allocate time within their positions to CoARA activities.

6. Promote exchange of practices and experiences

Communicate CoARA activities (AP 7.1)

We will raise awareness and stimulate engagement through external and internal communication channels such as websites and seminars. LiU will seek collaboration with other HEIs in Sweden and has on-going discussion on forming mutual working groups in certain areas.

Dialogue about CoARA with LiU Management and the head of the LiU departments (AP 7.2)

There will be regular meetings with LiU management and with the heads of LiUs department updating and discussing CoARA activities.

Introduce a researcher lounge for in-depth discussions on topics concerning CoARA and open science (AP 7.4)

This will be a physical meeting place with a limited number of attendees for in-depth discussions to complement digital meetings with invited speakers. Different topics can have either a broad audience or be more tailored.

Knowledge exchange through participation in working groups (AP 8.1)

LiU is participating in national and international working groups, such as within the ECIU University (European consortium of innovative universities) and the Swedish National chapter (NC) of CoARA. LiU participates in the NC WG on i) Good practice in evaluation of researchers, research education, and career paths, ii) Responsible bibliometrics, and iii) Incentives for open science.

Table 1. CoARA commitments (from the CoARA Agreement Annex 4), and LiU action points.

	CoARA commitment	LiU action plan
1	Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research	Revise the LiU employment rules, processes and associated documents (AP 1.1). Identify the most important research output of LiUs divisions (AP 1.2). Promote open science (AP 1.3). Review and develop the LiU salary revision criteria (AP 1.4).
2	Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators	Refine the department dialogues (AP 2.1). Advance the process for external peer review of research at LiU (AP 2.2).
3	Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index	Review and develop responsible use of bibliometrics at LiU (AP 3.1).
4	Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment	NA in the first AP
5	Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to	Allocate resources to CoARA activities (AP 5.1).
6	Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes	
	[Part 1 – Criteria for units and institutions] With the direct involvement of research organizations and researchers at all career stages, review and develop criteria for assessing research units and research performing organizations, while promoting interoperability	Characterize each of LiUs divisions in terms of their most important research output (AP 1.2). Refine the department dialogues (AP 2.1). Review the criteria for research assessment applied to LiUs divisions (AP 6.1).
	[Part 2 – Criteria for projects and researchers] With the direct involvement of researchers at all career stages, review and develop criteria, tools and processes for the assessment of research projects, research teams and researchers that are adapted to	Review and develop the LiU employment rules, processes and associated documents (AP 1.1). Review criteria for research assessment when applied to LiUs divisions (AP 6.1).

	their context of application	
7	Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use	Communicate CoARA activities (AP 7.1). Dialogue about CoARA with LiU Management and the head of the LiU departments (AP 7.2). Faculty or department specific webinars on research dissemination and responsible bibliometrics (AP 7.3). Introduce a researcher lounge for in-depth discussions on topics concerning CoARA and open science (AP 7.4).
8	Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition	Knowledge exchange through participation in working groups (AP 8.1).
9	Communicate progress made on adherence to the Principles and implementation of the Commitments	NA in the first AP
10	Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research	NA in the first AP